

12.1 Proxies, Servers, And Proxy Servers

There is actually a lot of terminology involved that's commonly (and loosely) used to mean a lot of slightly different things. A proxy is a service that takes a request from a client connected to it and forwards it to a designated server. It then obtains the required information and passes it back to the client. The proxy server thus acts as an intermediary between the client and the host; it makes the request *on behalf of the client*, as a "proxy."

A proxy server that passes on all requests to the host and sends back the replies unmodified is called a *tunnelling proxy*.

A *Web proxy* would be one that primarily deals with WWW traffic, and in some cases might reformat Web pages to suit a specific requirement. For instance, a cell phone with limited browsing capabilities would not be able to display complex graphical elements or the results of complex scripts, and a request from it would be reformatted by a Web proxy to fit its screen.

Anonymous proxies are used to bypass local access restrictions to, for example, gaming sites that may have been banned on a school network. These constitute a special type of Web proxy. They work by masking the IP of the client so that its identity is not known, and the client-side software does not recognise it as the IP making the request.

Proxy server software is primarily used to manage user access to the Internet, maintain a cache for improving access times, and to enforce an overall set of rules by which access should be governed on the network.

There are lots of software vendors who offer comprehensive suites of proxy server software to monitor and control Internet traffic over a network, such as Proxy+, Proxy-Pro, and CCProxy, among others. These have quite a lot of features built into them and some of them even offer online support. But most important-